New Scholarships Will Help Foster Care Students Go to College

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Melania Trump on Saturday announced a multimillion-dollar partnership between Louisiana State University and her "Fostering the Future" program to provide scholarships for LSU students who came through the foster care system.

"This achievement will give young people from foster care an anchor of stability, a strong educational foundation and a chance to build a wonderful life," she said at an event with LSU President Wade Rousse.

Trump and LSU secured more than $7 million in private donations to create an **endowment fund** for the scholarships, the White House said. MMR Group Inc., an electrical contracting company based in Baton Rouge, committed $5 million, with additional LSU Foundation donors providing more than $2 million.

There are 14 scholars under the program at LSU and nine at Alabama, she said, part of a group of 100 students supported across 26 schools this semester. The first lady later planned to attend the football game between LSU and Alabama, which also participates in the initiative. The foster care program was featured across the campus as well as on the field at Tiger Stadium just before kickoff.

"As adults, we have a **moral obligation** to our children, especially those in foster care. But, as you know, we must act to truly make a difference. The foster care community doesn't need words," she added, before concluding her brief remarks by saying, "Now, let's go and enjoy the game."

Rousse presented her with an LSU helmet with the "Be Best" logo and an LSU jersey with the "Be Best" patch that he said every player would wear in the game. The broader "Fostering the Future" initiative is an **offshoot** of the "Be Best" campaign that was her signature issue during President Donald Trump's first term.

"At LSU, we believe talent is everywhere but we understand that opportunity is not," Rousse said. "That is why access is one of our highest priorities. Students who have experienced foster care have already demonstrated **resilience**, determination and potential. Our responsibility is to make sure circumstances beyond their control do not stand between them and a life-changing higher educational experience."

The first lady started working on foster care issues after the Republican president's first term ended in 2021, and created "Fostering the Future" to provide resources and support, including scholarships. LSU is among more than 20 colleges and universities nationwide that participate in the program. Earlier this year, Melania Trump was on Capitol Hill to push Congress to pass a legislative package that would broaden access to services for young people in foster care by updating a decades-old program. The measures cleared the House and are pending in the Senate. Last November, she **spearheaded** an executive order signed by the president linking the federal government, colleges and universities, the private sector, and charitable groups to create educational and employment opportunities for young people

leaving foster care.

Word Treasure

endowment fund -- A pot of donated money that is kept and used to pay for something year after year.

moral obligation -- A strong feeling that you ought to do the right thing.

offshoot -- Something that grows out of an earlier idea or project.

resilience -- The ability to keep going and recover after hard times.

spearheaded -- Led an effort or project from the front.

Background you need

Foster care is a system that looks after children who cannot live safely with their own families, and young people who grow up in it often have less support when they become adults.

College can be hard to afford without family help, so scholarships and other support can make a real difference for these students.

"Fostering the Future" is a program that gives resources and scholarships to young people who have been in foster care, and it works with colleges and universities across the country.

An endowment fund is a pot of donated money that is kept and invested so it can keep paying for scholarships year after year.

Break it down

LEAD: Melania Trump announced a multimillion-dollar partnership between LSU and her 'Fostering the Future' program to fund scholarships for students who came through foster care.

KEY EVENT: More than $7 million in private donations will create an endowment fund for the scholarships.

+- WHO: MMR Group Inc., an electrical contracting company based in Baton Rouge, committed $5 million, with additional LSU Foundation donors giving more than $2 million.

+- SCALE: There are 14 scholars at LSU and nine at Alabama, part of 100 students across 26 schools this semester.

KEY EVENT: The announcement took place at an event with LSU President Wade Rousse, before the LSU-Alabama football game.

+- WORDS: Trump said the scholarships will give young people from foster care stability, an education, and a chance to build a wonderful life.

+- WORDS: Rousse said talent is everywhere but opportunity is not, and access is one of LSU's highest priorities.

+- SYMBOL: Rousse gave her an LSU helmet and jersey with the 'Be Best' logo, which every player would wear in the game.

KEY EVENT: 'Fostering the Future' grew out of the 'Be Best' campaign from President Donald Trump's first term.

+- HISTORY: The first lady began working on foster care after the first term ended in 2021, and LSU is among more than 20 colleges in the program.

+- POLITICS: She pushed Congress to pass a package broadening services for foster youth; it cleared the House and is pending in the Senate, and last November she led an executive order on education and jobs for young people leaving foster care.

OPEN QUESTION: Will the endowment fund be enough to support foster care students at LSU in the years to come?

Why it matters

Students who grow up in foster care often reach adulthood with little family support, so scholarships can decide whether college is possible at all. This partnership shows how private donations and universities can work together to close that gap.

Test what you remember

1. How much did Trump and LSU secure in private donations for the scholarships?

- (A) More than $5 million
- (B) More than $7 million
- (C) More than $20 million
- (D) More than $2 million

2. How much did MMR Group Inc. commit?

- (A) $2 million
- (B) $1 million
- (C) $5 million
- (D) $7 million

3. How many scholars are in the program at LSU?

- (A) 26
- (B) 14
- (C) 9
- (D) 100

4. How many students are supported across 26 schools this semester?

- (A) 26
- (B) 20
- (C) 100
- (D) 14

5. What did Rousse present to the first lady?

- (A) A scholarship check
- (B) An LSU helmet and jersey with the "Be Best" logo
- (C) A trophy
- (D) A football signed by the team

6. What happened to the legislative package Melania Trump pushed Congress to pass?

- (A) It cleared the House and is pending in the Senate
- (B) It was signed into law
- (C) It was voted down in the House
- (D) It was withdrawn

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: B 2: C 3: B 4: C 5: B 6: A

Questions to think about

1. Melania Trump: Says the scholarships will give young people from foster care stability, a strong education, and a chance to build a wonderful life, and that adults have a moral obligation to act for children in foster care.

2. LSU President Wade Rousse: Says talent is everywhere but opportunity is not, and that LSU must make sure circumstances beyond students' control do not block them from a life-changing education.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):